

1.1 Pg 8. The Synodikon of the Holy and Ecumenical Seventh Council

The church exclusively has the authority to proclaim dogma

This is a commentary, explanation, and amplification of the book "The Orthodox Faith, Worship, and Life, Orthodox Catechism: An outline." These notes are intended to be watched or read in conjunction with reading chapters in this excellent book. Sometimes, there are things unsaid that a beginner might not understand, so we have attempted to fill in some of the gaps that we have seen in the catechisms we have taught. This book is very deep, and you should read it slowly and look at the references. One of the problems with books, in my opinion, is they give a reference, but then they don't give you the text. Even when the author shows the text, you might want to look at the context.

VIDEO:

AUDIO: http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/catechism_2024+orthodox-faith-worship-and-life-orthodox-catechism-008.mp3

TEXT: (differs slightly from video and audio)

http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/catechism_2024+orthodox-faith-worship-and-life-orthodox-catechism-008.docx

http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/catechism_2024+orthodox-faith-worship-and-life-orthodox-catechism-008.pdf

Page 8: Before the First Chapter begins a portion of the "**Synodikon of the Holy and Ecumenical Seventh Council**" is given.

The quotation in the book is the most famous part of the Synodikon and is very inspiring:

"As the prophets have seen,
as the apostle have taught,
as the church has received,
as the teachers are set forth in dogmas,
as the whole world together with them has believed,
as Grace has shone forth,
as the truth was demonstrated,
as falsehood was banished,
as wisdom was emboldened,
as Christ has awarded;
thus do we believe, thus do we speak...

This is the faith of the apostles, this is the faith of the fathers, this is the faith of the Orthodox, this faith made fast the whole world."

A "**synod**" is a gathering together of people; in the Orthodox context, it is a gathering of bishops in order to discuss church doctrines and discipline. There have been many synods, and all local churches have them regularly, but the great synods have been the ecumenical synods (or councils).

A "**synodikon**" is an official definition published by a synod, a letter, or statement. We will be studying the

"Symbol of Faith," also known as the "Creed" or the "Nicene Creed," in detail. It is a "Synodikon" - an official and binding statement released from the proceedings of the first and the second ecumenical councils, in the year 325 (Nicaea) and 381 (Constantinople).

We can see the first recorded "Synodikon" in the Acts of the Apostles, when a letter was released by the

Apostles after they deliberated the false teachings of many Jewish Christians: “And certain men which came down from Judaea taught the brethren, *and said*, Except ye be circumcised after the manner of Moses, ye cannot be saved.” Acts 15:1 KJV

You should read this entire account in **Acts 15:1-35**. The “Synodikon” they released, with the full knowledge that their letter was binding to all who read it was: “Then pleased it the apostles and elders, with the whole church, to send chosen men of their own company to Antioch with Paul and Barnabas; *namely*, Judas surnamed Barsabas, and Silas, chief men among the brethren: (23) And they wrote *letters* by them after this manner; The apostles and elders and brethren *send* greeting unto the brethren which are of the Gentiles in Antioch and Syria and Cilicia: (24) Forasmuch as we have heard, that certain which went out from us have troubled you with words, subverting your souls, saying, *Ye must* be circumcised, and keep the law: to whom we gave no *such* commandment: (25) It seemed good unto us, being assembled with one accord, to send chosen men unto you with our beloved Barnabas and Paul, (26) Men that have hazarded their lives for the name of our Lord Jesus Christ. (27) We have sent therefore Judas and Silas, who shall also tell *you* the same things by mouth. (28) For it seemed good to the Holy Ghost, and to us, to lay upon you no greater burden than these necessary things; (29) That ye abstain from meats offered to idols, and from blood, and from things strangled, and from fornication: from which if ye keep yourselves, ye shall do well. Fare ye well.” Acts 15:22-29 KJV

It is noteworthy that the “**Synodikon of the Holy and Ecumenical Seventh Council**” was published from a Synod of 843 (which is many years after the 7th Ecumenical Council, which was in 787)! You should

look it up! (<https://www.iohnsanidopoulos.com/2010/02/synodicon-of-orthodoxy.html>)

This was well before Martin Luther or any other so-called “reformer”. One of the greatest arguments for the doctrines of the Orthodox Church is it they have been promulgated in writing and practiced for hundreds of years, even thousands, without change.

Everybody else changed. The Latins changed the faith with their various heresies such as Papism, and the filioque.

The “filioque” is an addition to the “Symbol of Faith”, which in its original, and unchangeable form read “and in the Holy Spirit, the Lord, the Giver of life, who proceeds from the Father” The Latins added the phrase: “and the son”, and in so doing changed the phrase to be “and in the Holy Spirit, the Lord, the Giver of life, who proceeds from the Father *and the Son.*”) The Latins made this change in their official dogma because of their arrogance and their Papism, despite the fact, of which they were well aware, that any change to the Symbol of Faith was forbidden by all of the subsequent ecumenical councils.

We will describe “Papism” in more detail in another place, but suffice it to be sufficient now to say that “Papism” is the erroneous belief that the Pope of Rome is the sole bishop in full authority over all the other bishops of the world. This is in absolute contradiction to the way the apostles conducted themselves; they all treated each other as equals. To this day, in the Orthodox faith, all bishops are considered to be equals in authority. No bishop is allowed to interfere with the dealings of another bishop in his diocese. The fundamental doctrine of Papism is that the Pope can appoint bishops and

remove them and he is the sole person who can declare a doctrine that is obligatory to believe.

It may be possible to have a reasonably comprehensive list of the errors of the Latins, but it is truly impossible to list all of the errors of other branches from their tree, starting with Martin Luther and all the rest.

Only after the Latins fell into massive heresies and immoral conduct, which helped bring about reformers such as Luther and Calvin, did the supposed Christian faith evolve into basically a faith that did not believe in the church and the church's authority to proclaim dogma. Once a "Christianity" is formed that is "churchless," then any dogma or practice can be changed by anyone with any justification, including the doctrine of what the church is!

There are a bewildering array of people who identify as Christians and believe everything and anything. Some will consider having an icon on the wall to be idolatry, some have no priesthood, some do not practice the Eucharist or consider it to be only a symbol, for some there is confession, for most there is not, there are even those who do not practice baptism, and there is every variant practice of baptism one can think of under the sun. There are many who think the prayer to saints to be idolatrous or at least unnecessary, and there are those who would not pray for the dead because I think it is a heresy to do so. There is a "legion" - we are using this word purposefully - of variant beliefs and practices, and they keep multiplying every day. In our day, we even have a redefinition of Christianity that prevents or even promotes sexual perversity and the allowance of the inclusion of pagan practices, all in the interest of love and inclusivity.

All these errors stem from not having the belief in the exclusive authority of the church to proclaim dogma, practice, and discipline.

We are saved from these abominable things by being obedient members of the church. As obedient members of the church, believing that Christ is the body of the church and the head of the church is Christ, we believe that the church has the authority to proclaim things both about dogma and about our personal conduct. That's why we recite the Creed and don't change one word. That's why we have fasting rules and rules about the age a person can be ordained and a multitude of other things because the church has a right, being the body of Christ, to tell us things.

For some catechumens, this will be a great hurdle.

They may believe in an authoritative church with their mind, but their heart does not believe it because it has been their practice all their lives to determine the theology they believe by reading the Bible and making a personal determination. You will go far in life if you just submit yourself to the mind of the church. That mind, of course, is Christ.

It is impossible to read Orthodox ascetical literature without being profoundly impressed with the humility of Orthodox Christians, especially the saints. We lack this humility, have been brought up in a cultural crucible that is full of self-reliance, and we should be humble enough to admit it. Therefore, for the inquirer and for every other person on the planet, a very good prayer to say every day, even with a prostration, would be: *"Lord Jesus Christ, help me to become truly humble."* God will always answer these sorts of prayers.

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